

SPOT OF MODERNITY
The Evoke Dholavira resort, near the Harrappan city of Dholavira

Gafur's walls. There were other famous people, like Shabana Azmi, Waheeda Rehman, Asha Parekh, and Shekhar Kapur.

November was still early to spot the flamingos flying in from Afghanistan or West Asia, images of which I had seen online of the Kutch. "The flamingos still haven't received their visas," joked Iqbal. "Locals here say they are migratory, but I think they are NRIs." There were no flamingos on our drive to the Harappan city of Dholavira, which cut through the newly constructed 30-kilometre 'Road to Heaven,' one of India's top ten roads. It was a name that was given by a Gen-Z blogger but has since caught on.

Travellers along the route are greeted first by the Arabian Sea's backwaters and then the beauty of the salt flats as they merge with the blue skies. The high tide during the months of May and June every year bring water into the bowl-shaped Kutch, a shape it acquired after the 2002 Bhuj earthquake. The blazing sun evaporated the water, leaving behind a thin film of a gorgeous salt desert. The route was so scenic that nearly everyone stopped their buses, mini-vans, and cars to take photos. Some flew drones over the road as the water glistened in the noon heat.

As visitors traversed the Rann, they also travelled thousands of years back to the metropolis of the Harappans at Dholavira. This archaeological site was a short drive from the Evoke Dholavira resort. We got a glimpse into life with the Harappans, a people who built impressive cities, stored their grains in granaries, made beads, and regulated their water with a web of reservoirs. Sadly, unlike the Harappan chieftains, no authorities supervise who enters and exits this grand city today. Modern Indians walked all over ancient brick structures, littered freely, and had toppled makeshift fences at the site.

After a relaxing afternoon in Evoke Dholavira, which showed off rare photos of the Dholavira excavations on its walls, we went on a short drive to the Wood Fossil Park. We piled into a green safari vehicle, which bumped along the route past a giant fibreglass squid and comically designed dinosaurs. The landscape prompted more selfies if one desired. With Pakistan only 35 kilometres away, phone networks caught signals changing time zones to half an hour earlier. Amidst the sunset and the lull, it was hard for me not to perch on a rock to think back to how much had changed since the tree fossilised at that spot about 16 million years ago.

With our flight from Bhuj promising to take off this time, the road trip back to the city came with a few more stops. First, we went to another perfect spot to explore the white desert for one last time and then sample the Kutch delicacy, *maava* cake, made of buffalo milk.

Sitting on a charpoy on a highway to Bhuj, drinking chai made of buffalo milk from a saucer, I thought of the white Rann. Its expanse had made me feel insignificant, and I realised that even salt, if spread evenly over the earth, could look magical. Visiting the Rann of Kutch is a must if you're was low on sodium!

The three days of hanging out with water and salt and the sights of Kutch made me agree with the adage: "Kutch *nahin dekha toh kuch nahin dekha*." Even the flamingos will agree. ■